

Meeting 4: Research Design Returned

Discussing your C3 drafts and next steps
Bachelor Project 2025–2026

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Wednesday 13 May 2026
Mandeville T3-09, 12:00–14:45

Today's Agenda

1. Method walkthroughs on the course site
2. Where you are this week
3. What A4 was meant to settle
4. Walking through each project
5. Privacy checklists
6. What A5 looks like

Method walkthroughs on the course site

Three short walkthroughs are now on the course page on my personal site, under **Methods walkthroughs** (same password).

- OLS regression in R
- Panel data with fixed effects in R
- NLP pipeline in Python

Each one runs end to end on simulated data themed around digital governance, so you can adapt the code to your own design. These are the basics and the baseline expectation for a bachelor's thesis. Feel free to add complexity for the relevant estimation method, as long as you understand what you are doing. Optional, not required. Read whichever is closest to the method you are weighing for A4.

Where you are this week

Working across the group

- Conceptual models with directions of effect
- Operationalisation moving from concepts to indicators
- Specific datasets named (V-Dem DSP, AidData, OVD-Info, Wayback, Lighthouse)
- Hypotheses committing to a direction

Still to land for A5

- For most of you, data construction has not started yet
- Operationalisation tables where the design has several indicators
- C3 in continuous prose where outline-style notes remain
- Word count on the cover for every submission

What A4 was meant to settle

By A4, every project should have established:

1. A **named source** for each variable (which dataset, which corpus, which platform)
2. A **measurement rule** for each concept (which V-Dem indicator, which clause category, which legal article)
3. A **time window** (start year, end year, and any lag)
4. A **sample frame** (which countries, which platforms, which municipalities, which cases)
5. An **ethics line** that names the actual risk, not a generic disclaimer

Where any of these is still open in your draft, that is the work to close before A5. The written feedback I sent this week names the specific item for each of you.

How the next 2h45 will run

Two groups of four, about 20 minutes per person, with a 5-minute break between groups:

1. I read your equation back to you.
2. Your cross-feedback partner opens with one execution question.
3. We open it to the room.
4. You leave with one commitment for A5 (Tuesday 19 May, 11:00).

$$\text{Outcome} = \text{effect} \times \text{the thing you think drives it} + (\text{controls})$$

Every term in the equation should now have a dataset and a coding rule.

Group A: 12:00–13:20

Text-as-data and cross-national designs

Cross-feedback pairs: Kate ↔ Lea Kseniya ↔ Daniel

Kate Domnikoff: regulatory complexity (GDPR $\times$ DMA)

Where you are: C2 has the Robb taxonomy and the responsive-regulation pyramid in place. C3 not in this submission; Section 3 still a placeholder. Two deliverables missing.

Compliance outcome = effect $\times$ **Textual complexity index** + (firm size, sector)

Discuss with Lea, then with the room:

- **Rename “psychological complexity”** in the variable list. Halstead measures textual/structural complexity, not psychological states.
- **Y conflates two constructs:** “warnings + companies implementing” treats enforcement counts and firm-level implementation as additive, but they pull in opposite directions. Pick one (DPA decisions for GDPR plus Commission fines for DMA is the cleanest).
- **Asymmetric coverage:** GDPR enforced from 2018, DMA only from 2023. Acknowledge as a limit, or align to a common post-2023 window.
- **Halstead on legal text:** one paragraph in C3 on operator vs operand when the “code” is GDPR and DMA articles.

Lea Géciová: protective vs oppressive digital sovereignty

Where you are: Two composite indices built (3 V-Dem items each, after dropping v2smpolcap), panel 2011–2023, OECD-38, Maerz (2025) as convergent-validity anchor.

$$\text{Internet freedom} = \beta_1 \times \text{Protective DS} + \beta_2 \times \text{Oppressive DS} + \text{moderation by libdem}$$

Hypothesis: β_1 neutral or positive, β_2 negative on freedom.

Discuss with Kate, then with the room:

- **DV construct validity:** v2smforads and v2smfordom measure foreign-actor behaviour, not domestic restriction. Drop them; rebuild Y from domestic-practice indicators. Fix the duplicate v2smgovsmcenprc.
- **v2smregcap as control:** overlaps with three of your index components. Drop; replace with internet penetration rate (World Bank IT.NET.USER.ZS).
- **H3a vs H3b** do the same work (linear moderation vs threshold). Pick one.
- **Op table for A5:** five composite items plus moderator plus controls in one table.

Kseniya Sidorenko: digital mobilisation and sentencing severity

Where you are: Full C3 in 1,665 words; ordered logit with interaction; three robustness checks; ethics handled. Strongest A4 submission.

$$\text{Sentence severity (0-7)} = \beta_1 \times \text{Visibility} + \beta_2 \times \text{Post-Feb 2022} + \beta_3 \times \text{Visibility} \times \text{Post-Feb 2022} + \text{controls}$$

The empirical question is whether $\beta_3 \neq 0$.

Discuss with Daniel, then with the room:

- **Pre-trial detention** is the biggest plausible confound on the mobilisation coefficient. Can you extract a detention flag from OVD-Info case text? Cursor would help.
- **Cut-point sensitivity:** the war became visible in the preceding weeks. Robustness shift of ± 7 and ± 14 days on the 21 February 2022 indicator.
- **Marginal effects** for the interaction in ordered logit, not the raw coefficient. Plan this for the results chapter.
- **Article 282.2 robustness:** confirm enough cases on both sides of the cut before A5; if not, swap to the top three or four articles pooled.

Daniel Ugarte: digitally restrictive legislation and backsliding (HU)

Where you are: H2 stated, conceptual model has the framing mechanism, methodology has dictionary-based content analysis plus process tracing. RQ currently packs two questions into one sentence.

$$\text{H1: } V\text{-Dem}_t = \beta \times \text{Restrictive laws}_{t-k}$$

$$\text{H2: Restrictiveness score of law} = \beta \times \text{Year passed}$$

Discuss with Kseniya, then with the room:

- **Fill the dictionary:** four categories (overt, covert, channeling, vague language), five Hungarian terms each, tied to Earl / Feldstein / Roberts / Schumann / Varol.
- **Hungarian originals** for dictionary application; DeepL only for the qualitative process-tracing read.
- **Split the RQ:** one main question, two sub-questions (sequencing, mechanism), not one sentence with “and”. H1 wording is ambiguous; tighten.
- **V-Dem is annual:** flag in limitations that this caps precision for closely spaced laws.

Group B: 13:25–14:45

Case, applied, and mixed designs

Cross-feedback pairs: Anand ↔ Vince Francis ↔ Louiza

Anand Dev Esponda: ownership concentration and Gen Z trust (NL)

Where you are: Scope narrowed to Gen Z in the Netherlands but the population is still ambiguous (Dutch nationals vs US expats vs other internationals). C2 reorganised around three mechanisms. C3 in progress.

$$\text{Political trust (NL Gen Z)} = \text{effect} \times \text{Exposure to concentrated platforms} + \text{(controls)}$$

Discuss with Vince, then with the room:

- **Population and RQ target are intertwined.** Two cleanest combinations: (a) Dutch nationals studying generalised political trust with US and Dutch institutions as separate items (keeps scope, moves RQ past “US politics” alone); (b) US expats studying trust in US institutions (keeps RQ wording, harder to recruit). I lean to (a). Pick one; write exclusion criteria into sampling.
- **Theoretical bridge** (if Dutch nationals): why would a US ownership change affect Dutch users? Mechanism paragraph in C2 (algorithmic spillover, exposure to US content, categorical distrust of US-owned platforms).
- **Y from a NL source:** European Social Survey trust items, Eurobarometer, or own survey. Settle which before A5.
- **Own survey:** **target 150–200 respondents**, restrict to 18+ to avoid minor-consent. Pilot with 5 before the full run.

Vince Kromberg: ToS clauses and regulatory shocks

Where you are: Section 2.4 written, two hypotheses, three-stage analytical procedure (segmentation, classification, rubric-based scoring), three platforms across three measurement years.

ToS clause direction (+1 / 0 / -1) measured at 2017, 2019, 2024 across Upwork, Fiverr, AMT, on fee clauses and termination clauses

Discuss with Anand, then with the room:

- **RQ is literally truncated** in 1.2 (ends with a comma). Complete the sentence and align with the two hypotheses.
- **Theoretical bridge:** why would GDPR or DMA (none of Upwork/Fiverr/AMT designated) specifically affect fee and termination clauses? One paragraph in 2.3 or 2.4.
- **N is 9 platform-years.** Frame as descriptive content analysis with quantitative coding, not inferential hypothesis-testing. Soften “follows”/“produces” to “is associated with”.
- **Lock the rubric** as a table sourced to Weil, Rosenblat & Stark, Cohen. Confirm Wayback snapshots exist for all 9 platform-years.

Francis van Luyn: Digital Silk Road and ASEAN sovereignty

Where you are: Framework in place: lock-in via Bokolo, infrastructuring via Musiani, AidData v3.0 on X, V-Dem DSP on Y. Specific dataset and codebook questions answered in the written feedback.

$$\text{Digital sovereignty (DSP index)}_t = \text{effect} \times \text{Chinese-built infrastructure (AidData)}_{t-5} + \text{controls}$$

Country-year panel, ASEAN-10, X window 2013–2018, Y observations to 2023.

Discuss with Louiza, then with the room:

- **Y as a state-capacity index (Option A):** v2smregcap, v2smregapp, v2smgovcapsec, v2smprivex, v2smprivcon as one composite. Musiani stays in C2 as framing; empirical Y is state-centric. Need V-Dem main alongside DSP for regime controls.
- **Selection problem:** China does not invest randomly. Controls: libdem or polyarchy, GDP per capita, internet penetration, Western or Japanese FDI as alternative funding.
- **Unit of analysis is country-year**, not project. AidData collapses to country-year by ICT (22030) and telecom (22020) sector flows.
- **N small** ($10 \times \sim 10$): wild bootstrap for clustered SEs rather than the default.

Louiza Reysen: digital accessibility of German municipal websites

Where you are: C2 narrower (digital divide and institutional isomorphism). Path dependency added as a theoretical mechanism. C3 in outline form. RQ in C1 and C3 do not match.

$$\text{Accessibility score (Lighthouse)} = \beta_1 \times \text{Size} + \beta_2 \times \text{Website creation date} + \beta_3 \times \text{Political control}$$

Discuss with Francis, then with the room:

- **Federal vs municipal scope:** the RQ mentions both but they are different studies with different units. Pick municipal and drop the federal framing. Reconcile the C1 and C3 RQ wording.
- **Use the Lighthouse Accessibility score (0–100) directly,** not rescaled to 1–10. Specify whether you audit the homepage or a specific OZG service page.
- **Path dependency from Wayback:** pull data for 5–6 representative municipalities before A5 to see whether “creation date” returns first online presence or current CMS. IV may not survive empirically if dates are unreliable.
- **WCAG, not WGA** throughout C3. Bibliography needs at least 5 peer-reviewed articles (Statista, DESI, Lighthouse do not count).

Privacy checklists

All eight checklists are now signed and on file. Thank you.

- For projects with primary data from human participants, the informed consent form is required before any data is collected.
- For secondary-data projects, the checklist covers your use of public datasets and any AI tooling in your pipeline.
- If anything in your design changes between now and A6 (different population, different instrument, AI tool added), please flag it so we can reassess.

What A5 looks like (Tuesday 19 May, 11:00 on Canvas)

A5 is the progress check. What I am looking for is evidence that data construction has actually started, not just been planned. For each project that means something specific:

Panel designs	Merged country-year file built; descriptives on the key indices
Text-as-data	Corpus retrieved, segmented, first-pass coded on at least one document
Case data	Matched analytical dataset built; first model run
Web-scraping	Sample drawn, scraping tool tested on a small subset
Survey	Instrument drafted and piloted, or secondary survey dataset confirmed
C3 catch-up	A complete C3 in continuous prose

Meeting 5: Thursday 21 May, regular slot.

Discussion

Before you leave, around the room:

1. One sentence: what does your A5 deliverable look like on screen next Tuesday?
2. One thing that could realistically go wrong, and your plan B.
3. One question for the room that you do not yet have an answer to.

90 seconds each.

Key References

Operationalisation of contested concepts (digital governance):

- Mechkova, V., Pemstein, D., Seim, B. & Wilson, S.L. (2025). Measuring online political activity: introducing the DSP dataset. *Journal of Information Technology & Politics*, 22(3), 279–295.
- Maerz, S.F. (2025). How practices of digital authoritarianism harm democracy. *Democratization*, 33(1), 1–28.
- Schumann, M.P. (2026). Legalizing control: the rise of restrictive internet regulation in sub-Saharan Africa. *Democratization*, 33(1), 137–162.

Design and replication:

- King, G., Keohane, R.O. & Verba, S. (1994). *Designing Social Inquiry*. Princeton UP.
- Bryman, A. (2016). *Social Research Methods*, Ch. 7. Oxford UP.

Ethics:

- KNAW (2024). *Evaluation Committee Recommendations on Research Integrity*.

Questions?

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